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-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You
Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts*All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or
indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.**There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing
of other topics in the main exam.*

LEADERS LIKELY TO MEET ON SUMMIT SIDELINES

As Modi, Trump head to G7, face-off over death of sailors

**Jaishankar
lodges protest
over killing of 3
mariners; won't
tolerate blockade
violation: Rubio**

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 13

AS PRIME Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump head to the G7 summit in Evian-les-Bains in eastern France for a possible meeting and discussion on trade, their first in over a year after the slide in bilateral ties, India and the US faced off Saturday over American missile strikes on commercial ships in the Gulf region, killing three Indian seafarers in one such attack on June 10.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said he had spoken to US Secretary of State Marco Rubio — in a post on X, he said he had made the call Friday evening — and “reiterated »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Prime Minister Narendra Modi at a diaspora event in Nice, France, Saturday. X/@NARENDRAMODI

Trump and Shehbaz say peace deal signing today, Iran questions timing

**Eman Abouhassira, Steve
Holland & Saad Sayeed**

Dubai, Washington, June 13

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump and mediator Pakistan said Saturday an initial deal to end the war in the Middle East would be signed Sunday, although Iran denied the signing would

take place so soon.

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said the two sides had agreed on a framework for a peace deal and that Islamabad was preparing for an electronic signing Sunday, to be followed by technical-level talks next week.

Trump also said in a social

media post that the deal with Iran was scheduled to be signed Sunday and that the Strait of Hormuz, a vital artery for global oil supplies which Iran has blocked, would be immediately “open to all” after it was signed.

Earlier Saturday, Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth next Army chief, first from Armoured Corps in 30 yrs

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 13

LIEUTENANT GENERAL Dhiraj Seth will be the next Chief of the Army Staff, the Ministry of Defence announced Saturday.

An Armoured Corps officer, Lt Gen Seth is currently serving as the Army's Vice Chief. He will take over as the COAS on June 30 when current Army



Lt General Dhiraj Seth will take over as the COAS on June 30

chief, General Upendra Dwivedi, retires from service.

Lt Gen Seth will be the third Army chief from the 2nd Lancers, one of the oldest armoured regiments in the country, and the first Armoured Corps officer to be appointed Army chief in the last 30 years after General Shankar Roy Chowdhury (1994-97).

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

‘Brain-eating amoeba’ cases see surge in Kerala, 133 this year

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, June 13

A DECADE after detecting its first amoebic meningoencephalitis case in 2016, Kerala is seeing an alarming surge in the fatal infection, with 133 positive cases and 33 deaths in the first five months of 2026. A major chunk of the cases, according to the health department, are granulomatous amoebic encephalitis (GAE), caused by Acanthamoeba, a free-living amoeba found mainly in contaminated water.

The rise in amoebic meningoencephalitis cases is alarming, considering the state reported only eight cases between 2016 and 2023. However, the surge began in 2024, when Kerala recorded 36 positive cases and nine deaths across various districts. In 2025, the state reported 201 cases and 47 deaths. The figures have continued to rise this year, with positive cases already reaching 133 and deaths 33 till June 12.

Kerala's figures stand out in sharp contrast to the number of detected cases in other states and abroad. Since the first recorded case of PAM in 1971, India had reported only around two dozen cases till 2023. Research papers on PAM state that only 381 cases were reported globally between 1965 and 2018.

According to Kerala Director of Health Services Dr K J Reena, the spike in cases is mainly due to the state's rigorous testing of all unidentified encephalitis cases. "We are detecting more cases after all unidentified encephalitis cases are being subjected to all tests. Undetected encephalitis cases are very few in the state due to this rigorous testing and diagnosis," Dr Reena told The Indian Express.

The DHS said that earlier, most amoebic meningoencephalitis cases were Primary Amoebic Meningoencephalitis (PAM), caused by Naegleria fowleri. "Now, the PAM cases have come down in Kerala and

most of the cases detected are GAE, caused by another free-living amoeba called Acanthamoeba, which is ubiquitous in water bodies, soil and even dust. Apart from the tropical climate of the state, poor quality of water is a contributing factor for the increased presence of this amoeba. Our water bodies have vegetation, which is another conducive factor for the increased presence of Acanthamoeba. Most of the affected persons are aged ones with compromised immunity. PAM has a global fatality rate of 97 per cent but GAE has a better survival rate," she said.

In 2024, the Kerala health department designed a special treatment protocol and a standard operating procedure for the management of amoebic meningoencephalitis cases — becoming the first state in India to do so. This also helped early detection and reduced the mortality rate. The first Indian to survive the fatal infection was a 14-year-old in Kerala in 2024, and he was the 11th PAM survivor in the world.

Dr Anoop Kumar A S, director of Critical Care at Aster MIMS (North Kerala), also said rigorous testing is a key factor behind Kerala's increase in cases.

"Western medical literature shows that most PAM cases were detected during postmortems. Many Western countries do not have regular screening for PAM/GAE. Whereas in Kerala, we are diagnosing the cases and saving lives," he said.

Dr Anoop, who was instrumental in detecting the first Nipah case in Kerala in 2018, said water contamination can lead to an increased presence of Acanthamoeba. "Water quality is very poor in Kerala. High population density leads to contamination of water. Many households have their toilet pits close to open wells. Water bodies with high coliform bacterial counts are more likely to have a strong presence of Acanthamoeba, which feeds on various bacteria including E. coli," he said, calling for a detailed environmental study.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Modi, Trump head to G7

India's strong protest at the attacks by the US Navy in the Gulf that killed three Indian mariners" while underlining that "such lethal actions against commercial shipping are not justified".

Hours later, the US Department of State pushed back. Deputy Spokesperson Tommy Pigott said, "Secretary of State Marco Rubio spoke yesterday with Indian External Affairs Minister Subrahmanyam Jaishankar. The two officials discussed recent events in the Strait of Hormuz. The Secretary stressed that all commercial vessels should immediately comply with orders from US forces as they seek to uphold peace and security in the Strait. He underscored that violations of the US blockade and the illicit transport of Iranian oil will

not be tolerated."

The US statement, underlining its intent to enforce the naval blockade by making all commercial vessels comply with its orders, will escalate the row in India over the missile attacks on ships with Indian seafarers, and the death of three on board the MT Settebello.

Jaishankar, who was in Finland on a bilateral visit, called up Rubio, hours after the Ministry of External Affairs summoned the US charge d'affaires Jason Meeks for the second time in less than 48 hours over the attacks.

Rubio was in India last month, on a visit to repair ties that were severely strained in 2025 after Trump's claims of mediation between India and Pakistan post Operation Sindoor and Washington's deci-

sion to impose heavy tariffs on Delhi. The two countries are currently firming up a bilateral trade deal.

Modi, who reached France Saturday, will be attending the meeting of the G7 on June 16-17 and it is likely that he will have a conversation with Trump on the sidelines of the summit. This will be their first face-to-face interaction since February 2025 in Washington.

French diplomatic sources said President Emmanuel Macron will host a meeting on West Asia on the summit margins. Leaders from Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Oman are expected to attend. Modi and Trump too have been invited to the meeting — both the US and Iran have indicated that they are nearing a deal to end the crisis in West Asia.

Meanwhile, news agency Reuters, quoting a senior US administration official it did not identify, said US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer will travel to India the week after the G7 summit for further discussions on a possible trade deal.

According to the official, trade would be discussed during Trump's meeting with Modi, but no agreement on a trade deal was expected at the summit.

"We know that Prime Minister Modi is quite ambitious about the role he sees for India, the importance of the US-India relationship," the official told reporters, according to Reuters. "We think a potential trade deal is part of that."

Trump would insist on reaching "a very good deal," the official said, adding: "We think a very good deal is possible. I don't think we'll close that deal at the G7."

Peace deal

Esmaeil Baghaei cautioned against commenting on the timing the signing.

"We will have to wait and see about the exact date of the signing of the memorandum of understanding, although it will not be tomorrow," state media quoted Baghaei as saying. "The possibility of this happening in the coming days cannot be ruled out. However, due to the hesitation of the other side, we must be cautious in making any comments about this process."

A US official who spoke to reporters later declined to be drawn on the timing but said: "It's a great deal and a very strong deal."

It is not the first time the two sides have appeared close to an initial agreement on ending the war that began on February 28 with joint US-Israeli strikes on Iran, but Sharif said on X: "We are closer to a peace deal than ever before."

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said Friday that while changes in the deal were still possible, the tentative agreement showed his country had emerged stronger from the conflict. Hours after those remarks, US forces shot down multiple Iranian one-way attack drones heading toward Hormuz.

Iran has for months effectively blockaded the strait, and the US navy has blocked Iranian ports to reduce its oil exports.

The proposed memorandum of understanding calls for reopening the strait and lifting the US naval blockade, sources on all sides of the talks said.

Negotiations over Iran's nuclear programme — Trump's stated rationale for starting the war — would take place afterwards. "Iran is going to open up the Strait of Hormuz, that's a requirement. It could be open with no tolls. As they do that, we will lift our blockade," said the US official who spoke Saturday.

"It's going to happen in conjunction, and part of the next step, the phase after that, is going

to be the demining of the straits," the official said, indicating countries in the Group of Seven major powers could have a role in this.

Draft terms described to Reuters by multiple sources indicate the US would begin releasing billions of dollars in frozen Iranian assets and waive sanctions on its oil exports, in return for Iran opening the strait.

Iran's Fars news agency quoted Baghaei as saying the release of Iran's frozen assets was an integral part of the agreement and also that Iran would have to charge for services in the Strait of Hormuz. Iran's nuclear programme would be addressed during a 60-day period of talks. A US official said the agreement would ultimately lead to the dismantling of Iran's nuclear programme, with its stockpile of highly enriched uranium to be destroyed and removed.

But Araghchi said that Iran, which sources said has not accepted the dismantling of its nuclear programme, wanted to retain the uranium in diluted form.

—REUTERS

Army chief

Former Army chiefs General Maharaj Shri Rajendrasinhji Jadeja, also the first Chief of Army Staff of the Indian Army after Independence (1953 to 1955), and General Bipin Chandra Joshi (1993-94) were also commissioned into the 2nd Lancers.

Lt Gen Seth will oversee the ongoing absorption of technology, modern equipment and platforms in the Army, and the process of integration with the other services. He comes from a family with a military background, and people who have worked with him describe him as a meticulous officer and a keen sportsman. His brother is a senior naval officer.

An alumnus of the National Defence Academy, Khadakwasla, he was commissioned into the Armoured Corps in December 1986.

The Ministry of Defence, in a statement, said Lt Gen Seth has extensive experience across operational, strategic, capability development and institutional domains in a distinguished military career spanning nearly four decades. He has contributed significantly to the Indian Army's combat effectiveness and long-term transformation, it said.

His command assignments include an armoured regiment in the desert sector, an armoured brigade in the western theatre, and a counter-insurgency force in Jammu & Kashmir.

‘Canada offers range of energy options to India... after 2 yrs of tension, working methods better known to each other’

Visas have been an irritant, we need to do better... want to ensure people don’t feel this was a painful process, says Cooter

IT’S BEEN almost a year since India and Canada hit reset and announced their new envoys after relations plummeted in 2023 over then PM Justin Trudeau’s allegation of “potential” involvement of Indian government agents in the killing of Canada-based Khalistan separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar — a charge that India rejected as “absurd” and “motivated”.

PM Narendra Modi and his Canadian counterpart Mark Carney met at the G7 leaders’ Summit in Kananaskis in June 2025, marking the beginning of the restoration of ties. As PM Modi heads to France for the G7 leaders’ Summit next week where he is expected to hold talks with PM Carney, Canadian High Commissioner to India, **Christopher Cooter**, sat down for a wide-ranging interview to Shubhajit Roy, where he talked about the transformation in ties, security concerns due to Khalistan elements, cooperation in energy, defence, uranium supply, the West Asia war, and the changes he observed after returning to India where he was posted from 1997 to 2000 as a diplomat. Edited excerpts:

How did the transformation happen after PM Carney assumed office?

First, PM Carney leads a government focused on pragmatic relations with other countries. From the time he was first elected and came into office in March 2025, unexpected pressure came from the US on our economy. For 80-odd years with the US, we’ve had a very advanced relationship. And to have that challenged so directly, I think pushed the Canadian government into looking around where we can find other reliable partners.

And so a real push for diversification began in early 2025 and as the PM has said, India is the breakout country, particularly in the Indo-Pacific.

Second, a decision was taken to move the relationship forward. We had two years of trouble, tension, and he was determined to rectify that situation and move us forward in the relationship with India. India is an extremely important country for Canada and has been for decades. We’ve had our ups and downs, not only the last couple of years, but even when I was posted here in the 1990s. And I think he is committed to putting

this relationship back on track. And so the two Prime Ministers met. The Prime Minister invited Prime Minister Modi to Kananaskis G7 summit back in June last year. The two saw very much eye to eye... that we both needed to go forward together. And so it was agreed at that time that the two countries would appoint their two High Commissioners, myself and Dinesh Patnaik, to resume the relationship in September. Since then, when we both arrived, things have gone much faster than we expected. Both sides have had an accelerating commitment to an improvement in the relationship.

I want to ask about the security cooperation since the concerns of security have been there from pro-Khalistan as well as criminal groups, which the Indian government has mentioned several times. How are you tackling those concerns?

I think a lot of progress has been made in dealing with that. And the main thing that has been accomplished is the establishment of trust between the relevant agencies. So that really took off not long after I arrived here, when a very senior delegation of our security officials, led by the national security and intelligence advisor, came and met the Indian counterparts, and had a very frank discussion. It was followed by discussions virtually between the two sides over the next few months. In January, NSA (Ajit Doval) came to Canada with a delegation. And so essentially, they have established a kind of a regular dialogue, institutionalizing that discussion. Now, the outcome is they know each other better. Their working methods are better known to each other, the way in which we approach an issue versus the way India approaches it. Very practical things, but we made a lot of progress over the last eight months. I think that’s just going to continue as the temperature of the relationship, that part of that relationship, which was very tense, that’s moved on, and I think we’re now in a much better place. There will be bumps in the road. But we’ve got mechanisms which will allow us to deal with things in a more professional manner.

What is the status of the



EXPRESS
interview

CHRISTOPHER COOTER
CANADIAN HIGH COMMISSIONER TO INDIA

investigations and the trial in the Nijjar case which had disrupted the relationship?

That’s within the judicial process in Canada. So it’s going through those stages and, and that’s really all I can say about that at this point.

One of the fallouts of the disruption in the relationship was the issue of visas of students and travellers, because there’s a huge Indian diaspora in Canada. What is the status of that?

On the question of immigration and visas, there has been a slowing down in the last couple of years. A lot of people came to Canada. We didn’t really have housing. And for those seeking education in Canada, there were some institutions that were taking advantage of them. A lot of work has been done to clean that up. In doing so, they imposed some limits on how many students would come in. I think there was a wrong impression given in India that Canada somehow wasn’t welcome. This is not the case. And the PM himself said several times when he came here, Canada is proud to host 400,000 Indian students. That’s about 1% of our population, and that represents more students that are hosted by the EU, UK and Australia. It’s more than the US has... And in fact, those caps are not filled. There’s quite a bit of space between the cap and the number of students we’re actually receiving.

So it’s actually a good time to apply for an education in Canada, which is still, from a price perspective, excellent value. And Indian students are very highly regarded. We’ve had 26 Canadian university presidents come to India in the eight months or so... We understand that visas have been an irritant, not just that the numbers were lower or seemed to be lower, but also that it’s difficult and slow. So one of the outcomes of all these visits is we have been told in no uncertain terms by Indians, students, businesses and others

that we need to reform this. We need to do better at visas. We’ve taken that on board. I don’t know where that stands right now back home in Ottawa, but I know people are looking at that very seriously. We want to make sure the experience of someone applying for a visa... that they don’t feel this was a painful process. It should be a fair process.

When PM Carney visited India early this year, the defence dialogue was established. What are the sectors of cooperation being looked at?

Our defence sector at home is ramping up rapidly. We’ve established a defence procurement office, etc, so we’re just working that out, which will undoubtedly lead to some kind of commercial links we don’t have now. We do have a small defence footprint in India and we have quite a large defence industry in Canada, but overlooked because it’s been historically quite integrated with the US. But we’re looking to diversify that and do it rapidly. So I expect something coming out of the dialogue in private sector or commercial arrangements.

We are much more interested in the Indo-Pacific than we were in the past. So the two PMs discussed cooperation in space, and we have an old MoU between ISRO and Canada Space Agency... I think we’ll see a linkage between aerospace and defence.

The two sides have set a deadline for CEPA by 2026-end. What’s the progress? Are you confident it can be achieved by them?

I am confident because both Prime Ministers have said it shall be done. We had a long process that ended in 2023. We didn’t get very far with it. This is a fresh approach, it’s intended to be comprehensive.

With the political will being there, it will get done, and I think it will be good for both sides. So I think the trade agreement will elevate. We’ve got so much we can do together and the comple-

mentarity of the economies is so great I don’t think we’re going to let this opportunity go.

And what about the uranium deal for long-term uranium supply. India and Canada have been discussing this for at least a decade, are we going to see the uranium supply again?

Yes, so it’s not entirely new. With a shipment many years ago, we have an agreement, a nuclear agreement that goes back to 2015, we can proceed with this. Canada is a logical partner, because we have a very sizable amount of uranium. We have a lot of technology. We have the first SMR coming online in the near future. We have engineering companies that are experts in this field. So there’s a lot we can do beyond just the uranium itself.

When you’re talking about critical minerals, we’re talking about mining, energy infrastructure, and it does take a significant understanding of the path ahead. PM Carney said in his Davos speech that most of the countries are not very happy with economic coercion. They don’t want to be told you have to buy from this country or you can’t sell to that country. So when it comes to things like critical minerals, Canada offers a lot of options, and we know other countries have weaponised their source of critical minerals.

Does the war in West Asia make a case for a stronger India-Canada cooperation?

Absolutely, I think let’s hope it ends tomorrow. Let’s hope it ends today. No more casualties, stability returns. And undoubtedly, the Gulf countries would then resume their supply of LNG, LPG... But I think in Canada we offer something that would be more reliable and stable.

So the Indian demand for energy, 35% of all growth in energy demands over the next few years will come from India. We happen to be an energy superpower. Canada has the fourth largest oil reserves in the world, the fifth largest in LNG, fifth largest in LPG, the second or third largest in uranium. It’s number two in hydro. It’s doing a carbon capture. It has fuel cell technology. We’re the only G7 country producing batteries for EVs from indigenous materials. Canada has this huge range of energy options that are available now to India.

Maybe we won’t be more than 5% or 10% of your supply, but that’s enough to remove that shortage, which puts pressure on the price because of the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

It’s also beyond fuel, it’s also fertilizer which has affected urea

supply. We produce urea in Canada. We have a lot of LNG for which urea is produced. But we also produce potash. We do supply some potash to you. We would love to supply more. We would give you another source of supply on fertilizer, because India’s fertilizer demands are large and growing.

So those are two areas that the Gulf war has really highlighted... Canada is saying we offer you a partnership that is solid and reliable...

India has had a very complicated relationship with China and your PM was recently in Beijing. How do you view China’s rise and its approach in the Indo-Pacific, especially because Canada also came out with this Indo-Pacific strategy?

So, we’ve also had a complicated relationship with China. And I think the primary answer is, of course, China is going to be a huge player, not just in the Indo-Pacific, but globally... we will be adapting to that continuously. What we don’t want, however, is to be too dependent on China, both for supplies of certain things or as a market. And that drives us again to think about India as a major alternative to China. And we want to make sure Canada is diversifying more towards India. And while having a strong relationship with China, it’ll be a different kind of relationship. We’re also democracies or members of the Commonwealth. We have a large diaspora in Canada... we respect China. We want to have a good relationship with China. The PM was just there, but it will be qualitatively different with India and at the same time, the relationship will also expand. We have set 2030 for doubling trade. But I think we can be much more ambitious than that.

You were posted here 26 years ago as a diplomat. What has been the biggest change you saw after returning here?

There are obviously physical changes. Cities are bigger and that kind of thing, but the biggest change is actually the attitude. In the 1990s, you were just coming out of the license raj. Your economy was still highly protectionist and closed. When I arrived in 1997, there was a kind of defensive attitude as well. That’s gone now. Now, India is very open to the world. You had the G20 Summit... The confidence Indians have now wasn’t there 26 years ago. It’s a very nice confidence, not hubristic. Actually, we would like India to be more engaged in the world and take on a bigger role.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi departs for the six-day visit to France and Slovakia, Saturday. PTI

Modi in France: Tech, innovation to dominate bilateral agenda

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 13

TECH AND innovation are expected to dominate the bilateral agenda at Bharat Innovates 2026, to be inaugurated by PM Narendra Modi and French President Emmanuel Macron, in Nice, France, on Sunday. The event will bring together top innovation startups from India, France and the world.

Bharat Innovates 2026, being held during India-France Year of Innovation, reinforces the vibrant innovation partnership between the two countries. More than 120 Indian companies/startups and prominent business leaders, investors and CEOs from France and other countries are expected to participate in the event.

PM Modi arrived in Nice Saturday night as part of his six-day tour to France and Slovakia. He will be in Nice from June 13-14, then travel to Slovakia from June 14-16 and return to France for a two-day stay — June 16-18 — at Evian and Paris. He will hold the first bilateral summit with President Macron in Nice on Sunday after the elevation of ties to a ‘Special Global Strategic Partnership’.

With the war in West Asia leading to US blockade of ships going to or from Iranian ports through the Strait of Hormuz, Modi and Macron are also expected to discuss the ways and means of restoring freedom of navigation in the Strait.

Officials said they are expected to emphasise the importance of abiding by the ceasefire agreement reached between Iran and the US, and of finding a swift and lasting end to the war through diplomatic means.

PM Modi said in his departure statement, “France occupies a special place in India’s strategic vision. Earlier this year, President Macron visited India and we elevated our relationship to a Special Global Strategic Partnership. When I meet President Macron in Nice, we will review the progress made since February, and chart the next steps in our cooperation. I look forward

E. EXPLAINED

Focus on new partnerships

PM Narendra Modi’s participation in Bharat Innovates at Nice and Vivattech Summit at Evian in France will spotlight India as a global hub for innovation, digital transformation and entrepreneurship, and is expected to catalyse new partnerships between Indian and European technology ecosystems.

to our discussions on pressing global issues of mutual interest as well.”

Additional Secretary (Europe West), MEA, Piyush Srivastava said: “Bharat Innovates is a landmark initiative that showcases India’s innovation journey to a global audience, our startup ecosystem, deep tech startups, our digital public infrastructure, our advances in defence space and clean energy, and contributions of Indian talent to global technology. The PM’s presence with President Macron at this event is itself a significant symbol of the depth of bilateral relationship in the domain of technology and innovation. Especially this year, which we are also celebrating as India-France Year of Innovation.”

French diplomatic sources said about a dozen pacts and outcomes are expected to be signed and announced, with a focus on innovation, science and technology, economy, cultural and people-to-people ties.

In Evian, PM Modi will participate in the G7 Summit on June 16-17. “This is the 8th consecutive G7 Summit to which India has been invited. At the G7, India will not only speak for itself, but it will also give voice to the aspirations of the Global South,” Modi said in his statement. The PM will visit Paris on June 18, where alongside President Macron he will attend the VivaTech Summit, Europe’s largest tech and startup event.

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 13

A missile during a flight test conducted by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO). PTI

The maiden flight test of the Naval Anti-Ship Missile-Medium Range (NASM-MR)

Defence Minister Rajniath Singh has congratulated DRDO on successfully demonstrating these crucial technologies. DRDO Chairman Rajesh Kumar Singh monitored the trials and applauded the combined efforts of DRDO and industry.

Before next polls, SC wants SIR exclusion cases decided: A reality check from Assam

In 1997, around 3 lakh voters in Assam marked 'Doubtful' during intensive roll revision; ahead of this year's polls, the state had 93,000 'D' voters still, with cases dragging on

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, June 13

UPHOLDING THE legal validity of the SIR of electoral rolls by the Election Commission (EC) on May 27, the Supreme Court held that those excluded from the list will face "adjudication of their citizenship". It also directed that such cases be referred "within 4 weeks to the Competent Authority... (which) shall take the necessary decision in accordance with law, preferably before the next Parliamentary, Assembly, Local Body elections, whichever is earlier".

The Assam example is illustrative of why it will not be as easy as that.

It is the only state where the presence of voters in electoral lists has been contested on grounds of citizenship at this scale. In 1997, around 3 lakh of them were first marked 'D-voters' or 'Doubtful Voters' during an intensive revision of rolls. Ahead of this year's Assam As-

sembly elections, over 93,000 were still 'D' voters, with cases dragging on through tribunals and courts. There is no clear data on how many have been marked 'D' voters since 1997.

The revision of electoral rolls held nearly 30 years ago in Assam involved "verification" by 'Local Verification Officers (LVOs)' of cases of people who had been provisionally included in the draft voting list but where "linkages could not be established with earlier rolls". Establishing linkages with previous SIR in respective states is one of the prime requirements of the EC's ongoing SIR exercise too.

In Assam's case, the LVOs submitted reports to respective Election Registration Officers (EROs), and where the EROs "had reasonable doubt about the citizenship of any person", they forwarded the cases to the "competent authority", which was the SP of the district concerned. Police then referred these cases for "determination" to Foreigners'

Tribunals (FTs) or Illegal Migrants Determination Tribunals (IMDT), in place since 1964 and 1983 in Assam, respectively, due to its long history of immigration and citizenship anxieties.

After the IMDT Act was struck down as "unconstitutional" in 2005, all cases were transferred to FTs. Unlike in the case of IMDTs, where the onus on proving citizenship was on the complainant and the authorities, in the case of FTs, those accused of being suspected foreigners had to prove their case. (The Supreme Court's order giving the EC a four-week window to report the SIR deletions also essentially shifts the burden on the deleted individual to prove their citizenship.)

'D' was put after the names in the voter list of all people in Assam whose cases had not been decided by tribunals — indicating that their citizenship status was disputed or 'Doubtful'. If declared Indian, they would remain on the voter list,

with the 'D' mark removed, but if ruled to be foreigner, they would have their names deleted and be moved to detention centres pending deportation.

Following a Supreme Court order, those who have spent two years in detention centres without having their cases cleared can now be released on bail.

Lawyers who have been working on citizenship matters in Assam tell *The Indian Express* that the biggest round of mass marking of people as D-voters took place in 1997, but people were also tagged thus in 2005, when an intensive revision was conducted in Assam last.

In 2012, a 'White Paper on Foreigners Issue' brought out by Assam government recorded 2,31,657 such references to competent authorities. The paper said that between 1998 and July 2012 (14 years), 6,590 people had been declared foreigners by tribunals, while more than six times that number, 44,220, ended up being declared Indian.

In a recent submission before the Assembly, the Assam government said that until January 31, 2025, a little over 77,000 'D' voters had been declared Indians, while 1.18 lakh cases were

still pending.

Ahead of the Assam elections this year, the EC conducted a Special Revision in December 2025 — unlike the SIR in other poll-bound states, due to the different citizenship processes in Assam. In the voter list released after the Special Revision, the number of people marked as 'D' voters was 93,021.

The functioning of FTs has been frequently criticised as being "arbitrary", apart from drawing criticism over the long delays when cases reach them.

Senior Advocate Hafiz Rashid Ahmed Choudhury, who has represented many people before FTs, says the long drawn-out process means many wait years just for the chance to defend themselves at tribunals.

Choudhury points to another gap. "Once the 'D' was put against a name, it didn't mean a person had to come before a tribunal immediately... The ERO has to refer it to police, who in turn must refer it to the tribunal. Over the years, we have seen so many 'D' voters who are not able to fight their case in tribunals because it has not been referred, and they have not got the notice."

FTs are presided over by

quasi-judicial officers. A former FT member told *The Indian Express*: "Once a person appears before a tribunal with a written statement and documentary evidence, a case can be disposed of within a month. But there is institutional lethargy from all directions, as well as systemic problems like a lack of staff and facilities at tribunals."

There are currently 100 FTs in Assam. A Gauhati High Court Bench which monitors the functioning of these tribunals, in an order as recently as June 2, remarked on the lack of facilities in them, noting: "This also demonstrates that the intention of the Govt. is not to allow the Foreigners Tribunal to function in an appropriate manner."

Even after a person has been declared a foreigner by FTs, he or she has the option of moving the High Court and Supreme Court. In the most recent case, the Supreme Court ordered status quo on the deportation of five women, after they had lost their case before the Gauhati High Court and an FT.

Since last year, the Assam government has escalated a process of "pushbacks" or informal deportations into Bangladesh of declared foreigners.

Emerging tech has altered warfare, small powers can cause heavy losses: Rajnath



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh at the Air Force Academy in Dundigal on Saturday. PTI

Press Trust of India
Hyderabad, June 13

ASSERTING THAT recruits to the Armed Forces must be mentally prepared for the evolving nature of modern conflict, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday said major powers no longer hold an edge on the battlefield as even smaller forces can inflict significant damage using specialised tactics.

Addressing the Combined Graduation Parade (CGP) at the Air Force Academy at Dundigal, Singh also said emerging technologies have altered the very definition of warfare. "Earlier, it seemed that the big powers had a decisive edge on the battlefield. But now, comparatively, even small powers can cause heavy losses with their small but dangerous weapons and new tactics. ... you should be mentally ready for any form of warfare," he said.

"In contrast to the visibility of soldiers and equipment earlier, many systems such as radars, satellites, drones, sensors and robotics are deployed in modern warfare. Such scenarios are being witnessed now in which traffic systems and CCTVs of adversaries are being controlled," he said. According to him, the definition of warfare has changed. Newly commissioned officers should understand modern warfare and adapt, adopt, and, if necessary, amend them.



President Droupadi Murmu with the nine women cadets who were commissioned as officers in the Indian Army, at the Indian Military Academy in Dehradun on Saturday. MINISTRY OF DEFENCE

FIRST TIME, A PERMANENT COMMISSION FOR WOMEN OFFICERS

First batch of NDA-trained women cadets commissioned as officers

Express News Service
Pune, New Delhi, June 13

A YEAR after they walked past the symbolic Antim Pag — the final step — at the NDA in Pune, the first batch of 17 women cadets trained at the NDA was commissioned Saturday as officers, marking a significant milestone in the evolution of women's participation in military service.

This is the first time women officers will be joining the forces with a permanent commission. This was made possible by an interim order passed by the Supreme Court in August 2021, while hearing a plea seeking directions to let eligible women take the NDA and Naval Academy entrance exams conducted by the UPSC.

The first batch of women cadets joined the NDA in July-August 2022 as part of its 148th course.

So far, short service commission women officers could join the forces, and later seek permanent commission after completion of 14 years of service.

The batch of 17 women cadets have successfully completed their rigorous pre-commission training at their respective service academies, the Ministry of Defence said in a statement on Saturday.

"The commissioning marks a defining chapter in the transformation of the Defence Forces and reflects the nation's commitment to equal opportunity, merit and excellence in military service," the statement noted.

In the Indian Army, nine

women officers were commissioned during the Passing Out Parade of 158th Regular Course at IMA, Dehradun, on Saturday. The parade was reviewed by President Droupadi Murmu.

In the IAF, five officers were commissioned during the Combined Graduation Parade of 217th Course at the Air Force Academy, Dundigal, Hyderabad, on Saturday. The parade was reviewed by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh.

In the Indian Navy, three officers were commissioned during the Spring Term 2026 Passing Out Parade at the Indian Naval Academy, Ezhimala, Kerala, on May 28. The parade was reviewed by Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Southern Naval Command Vice Admiral Sameer Saxena.

Trafficked & tortured for 18 months, 2 Gujarat sisters rescued from Laos

Aditi Raja
Vadodra, June 13

IN DECEMBER 2024, two sisters from Anand district left home for Thailand, believing they were headed for their first employment abroad. The two women, both in their early 20s, returned home 18 months later on Friday after they were rescued by police in the Houaphan Province of Laos.

Police there had acted on an urgent diplomatic intervention by the Indian Embassy, official sources said.

Before their rescue, at least one of the two women was confined in a space that resembled a "3x3 kennel" for days to-

gether, the sources said, adding that the two were also subjected to physical torture. From Thailand, the two were reportedly taken to Myanmar against their will and held hostage for about a year. They were then sent to Laos via Cambodia.

Their safe return to Anand this week marked the conclusion of "Operation Mahisagar 2.0" — a crackdown against human trafficking to rescue residents of Anand held hostage abroad.

The two sisters were "traumatised and silent", family members said.

Meanwhile, Anand BJP MP Mitesh Patel, who had requested the Indian Embassy in

Laos to rescue the women, said, "The two sisters left for Thailand on December 4, 2024. After landing, they were picked up by a company vehicle and sent across the border to Myanmar without their informed consent. They were held there for about a year... They were subsequently moved to Cambodia, and later to Laos."

According to the sources, the two women "knew immediately" that they had been trapped but "did not share the news with their parents" hoping they would be able to eventually escape and return.

"The women did not want to cause anxiety among their families, but the torture in-

creased with each passing day," they added.

One of the two women was subjected to physical assault apart from being confined in tiny cage-like spaces along with several other foreign nationals, according to her family. In their last "free communication", the sisters texted their family stating that they were in Vientiane, Laos, and urged the relatives to search for them if they ever stopped hearing from them.

It was this message that rang a distress signal in Anand. The family reported to local authorities that the sisters were being subjected to harassment and torture by people associated with the company that

had taken them to Thailand.

Patel took up the matter with the Ministry of External Affairs, formally requesting emergency consular assistance, coordination with Lao law enforcement, and, if necessary, flagging the case with Interpol and anti-trafficking units.

In a written communication to the MP's office on June 4, the Indian Embassy confirmed that both girls had been rescued by the Lao police from the Houaphan Province. "With persistent follow-up and close coordination with Lao authorities, both women were rescued from the Houaphan Province," the Embassy had stated.

The women were first

brought to Vientiane for official formalities before being repatriated to India. On Friday, MP Patel visited their residence and inquired after the women.

"From the moment this matter came to my attention, we remained in constant contact with the MEA. Under the guidance of PM Narendra Modi and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, the Ministry and the Indian Embassy in Laos worked on a war footing," Patel said.

Earlier, Patel's office had intervened in rescuing two Anand residents who had been stranded in Azerbaijan while attempting to reach the United States through the 'dunk' route.



TEHRAN SEEKS TO PRESERVE ENRICHMENT RIGHTS, NUCLEAR KNOWHOW AND FUTURE THRESHOLD CAPABILITY

With a deal seemingly close, US faces an Iran willing to withstand pressure

Steven Erlanger
June 13

THE UNITED States and Israel went to war in Iran seeking regime change. Nearly four months later, there has been regime change, but not the kind they wanted. The Islamic Republic 3.0, as some call it, is now less a theocracy and more a military junta dominated by the powerful Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps.

Washington and Jerusalem also went to war to eradicate Iran's nuclear program and end the threat it poses. So far, this conflict has only produced a wounded Iran more willing to take risks and more likely to persist in its goal of advancing its nuclear program.

The United States and Iran traded blows this past week while trying to find a path toward settling the war. By Friday, despite accusations of duplicity from both sides, officials in

Tehran and Washington said they were closing in on a deal, while emphasizing that an initial agreement, known as a memorandum of understanding, had not been finalized. Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, said that an agreement had "never been closer."

Even agreement on the



A small motorboat passes anchored vessels in the Strait of Hormuz off Bandar Abbas, Iran. FILE

memorandum will leave Tehran with some leverage, as the two sides engage in serious negotiations on Iran's nuclear program and its future role in the Strait of Hormuz. Many details would be left to a 60-day period for negotiations, which may or may not succeed.

In the course of this war, Iran has gone from appearing weak and defenceless to a regime not only surviving, but also retaining important military and nuclear abilities. Iran's extensive se-

curity apparatus seems firmly in control of all aspects of governing, society and foreign policy.

Iran is now led by "a younger, more brazen generation in power," said Sanam Vakil, the director of the Middle East and North Africa program at Chatham House, in what Aaron David Miller, a former American diplomat at Carnegie Endowment, called "a transition from divine power to hard power."

These new leaders believe they can survive even a major re-

newal of fighting without significantly altering their negotiating positions or their larger regional aims. Those aims include to restore their power of deterrence so that they cannot be attacked again as they were in February.

They also want to maintain the right to enrich uranium, even at low levels after a period of suspension, and will retain the scientific knowledge and equipment that would allow them, should they choose, to again become a nuclear-threshold state,

E. EXPLAINED

Tehran gains leverage after war

After US-Israeli strikes aimed at regime change and stopping Iran's nuclear program, Tehran has survived with its military and nuclear capabilities intact. Negotiators now near a limited deal, but Iran is demanding enrichment rights, frozen assets and leverage over the Strait of Hormuz in talks.

one that would have all the elements of a nuclear weapon without having put one together.

The new Iranian government has shown itself to be a tough negotiator willing to accept a high level of pain to preserve its core interests.

This attitude is very different from the caution shown by the former supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was assassinated on the first day of the war, Feb. 28. He had for years banned the production of a nuclear weapon and always worked to avoid a joint Israeli-American attack on Iran. NYT

MARKET COUPLING OPERATOR PROPOSED FOR POWER TRADING

Sole MCO plan gets pushback from Grid India, IEX

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, June 13

SUPPORTING THE rollout of a market coupling mechanism in India — that seeks to discover uniform electricity price across exchanges — Grid Controller of India (Grid India) has called for establishment of a steering committee comprising key stakeholders to act as Market Coupling Operator (MCO).

In its draft CERC (Power Market) (Second Amendment) Regulations, 2026, issued in April, the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (CERC) had proposed designating Grid India as the sole MCO, responsible for the operation and management of market coupling.

While Power Exchange India Ltd (PXIL) and Hindustan Power Exchange Ltd (HPX) have supported designation of Grid India as MCO, Indian Energy Exchange (IEX) — the country's biggest power trading bourse — opposed the draft regulations' proposal.

India currently has three power exchanges regulated by CERC, where generators, distribution companies, traders and large consumers buy and sell electricity. IEX dominates the market with over 90% share, while PXIL and HPX account for the remainder.

Grid India, on its part, said the proposed designation of the state-owned grid operator as the sole MCO would simplify implementation and enable faster rollout of market coupling, but could also create a single point of failure for electricity market clearing.

While backing the proposal, GRID India said a regulatory fallback mechanism should be introduced to allow power exchanges to undertake price discovery in the event of a techni-



Power Exchange India Ltd (PXIL) and Hindustan Power Exchange Ltd (HPX) supported designation of Grid India as MCO. REUTERS

cal disruption at the MCO.

"... a single MCO design introduces a single point of failure. In case of any disruption, the entire market clearing function would be affected," it said, citing instances in Europe where technical issues led to partial decoupling of electricity markets.

"It is suggested that with a single MCO design, the necessary fallback regulatory mechanism may be introduced allowing the Power Exchanges to carry out price discovery in case of any technical failure at MCO," it added.

In its submission to the regulator, Grid India said the objectives of strengthening regulatory oversight and minimising the need for frequent interventions could be effectively met through a steering committee comprising CERC, Grid India, all power exchanges, and external auditors or market monitors. "The European model of round-robin implementation with a Steering Committee has been successful. This approach adds multiple (8-9) layers of redundancy, robustness, reproducibility and fail-proof price discovery, with a robust maker and checker mechanism," Grid India submitted to the regulator. The proposal in April's draft

regulation marked a shift from the regulator's earlier approach outlined in its July 2025 order directing the implementation of market coupling.

Under that framework, power exchanges were to act as the MCO on a rotational basis, with Grid India serving as the fourth MCO for backup and audit purposes.

Market coupling is a mechanism that aggregates bids from all power exchanges to determine a uniform market-clearing price for electricity.

First introduced under CERC's Power Market Regulations, 2021, the concept is aimed at improving price discovery, reducing price disparities across markets, and enhancing overall market efficiency and stability.

Grid India underscored the need of an institutional ring-fencing of market-coupling operations due to the conflicting nature of market clearing and ensuring reliability.

"With transfer of CTU to Grid-India currently underway, transmission planning, system operations and market operations would be under one umbrella, which may be grounds for potential conflict," it added.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Why an Assam-Nagaland pact raises hopes of higher oil & gas output from Northeast

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 13

THE UNION government, Assam and Nagaland Thursday signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) that paves the way for the resumption of oil and gas exploration along the resource-rich and contested boundary of the two states after three decades.

The Northeast is considered the birthplace of India's oil and gas industry and Assam is among India's major oil and gas producing states.

This agreement is part of that effort, and comes at a time when the country is grappling with high prices of imported oil and gas, as well as supply constraints, owing to the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz amid the West Asia war.

The government has implemented several policy reforms to encourage investments in India's oil and gas exploration and production sector.

Resumption of oil, gas exploration in contested border

Although these "upstream" activities have long gestation periods, the agreement could augment the country's domestic oil and gas production in the medium to long term. According to officials aware of

the matter, the MoU specifically targets the disputed area belt, or DAB, along the Assam-Nagaland border. With the MoU in place, oil and gas exploration and production are expected to gather pace across more than 1,000 sq km along the Assam-Nagaland border.

Oil, gas, and mineral exploration activities have remained suspended in the DAB for three decades owing to law and order issues amid boundary disputes between the two states.

The DAB is expected to contain promising hydrocarbon prospects. According to the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), the MoU establishes a coordinated framework for facilitating mineral oil operations in the area, ensuring operational continuity, safety and security of personnel and assets, and effective coordination among all stakeholders.

The framework is expected to support exploration and production activities, encourage investment in the upstream petroleum sector and contribute towards the country's energy security objectives, it said.

The MHA said that both states decided that they would not allow any obstacle to India's oil exploration, and would advance on the path of mutual co-operation, as these resources constitute national wealth.

According to the MHA re-



Oil, gas, and mineral exploration activities have remained suspended in the contested area for three decades now. REUTERS

lease, apart from six designated oil and gas fields, the Nagaland government has agreed to oil exploration across Nagaland.

"He (Home Minister Amit Shah) stated that the Government of Assam is also in agreement, as this is a win-win situation for all stakeholders. The Home Minister said that this tripartite agreement will pave the way for mineral exploration and mining across the entire North-East region," the release said.

Govt sees significant oil, gas potential in region

"Since Assam alone accounts for nearly 22% of India's crude oil reserves and around 15% of the country's natural gas

reserves, while Nagaland possesses significant hydrocarbon potential in the Naga-Schuppen Belt of the Assam-Arakan Basin, resources where hydrocarbons flow naturally and those which have huge untapped resources, the outlook for E&P [exploration and production] activities in the North East is therefore extremely promising," Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri posted on social media platform X, adding that the MoU paves the way for Nagaland to produce oil and gas after 31 years. According to the MHA release, Shah said that the MoU could potentially help increase oil production capacity from the Northeast from the current capacity of 1,000-1,500 barrels per day by more than

tenfold, adding that the region also possesses "and immense wealth of minerals". While it is difficult to predict exactly how soon this tripartite agreement would start bearing fruit, Shah emphasised that in due course it will bring significant relief to India and enhance the country's self-reliance.

"Union Home Minister Shri Amit Shah expressed confidence that the extraction of oil and gas resources available in Nagaland would significantly reduce India's dependence on foreign sources in this sector. He said that, in the absence of such an agreement and due to certain longstanding challenges, the economic development of both states had remained affected for a considerable period.

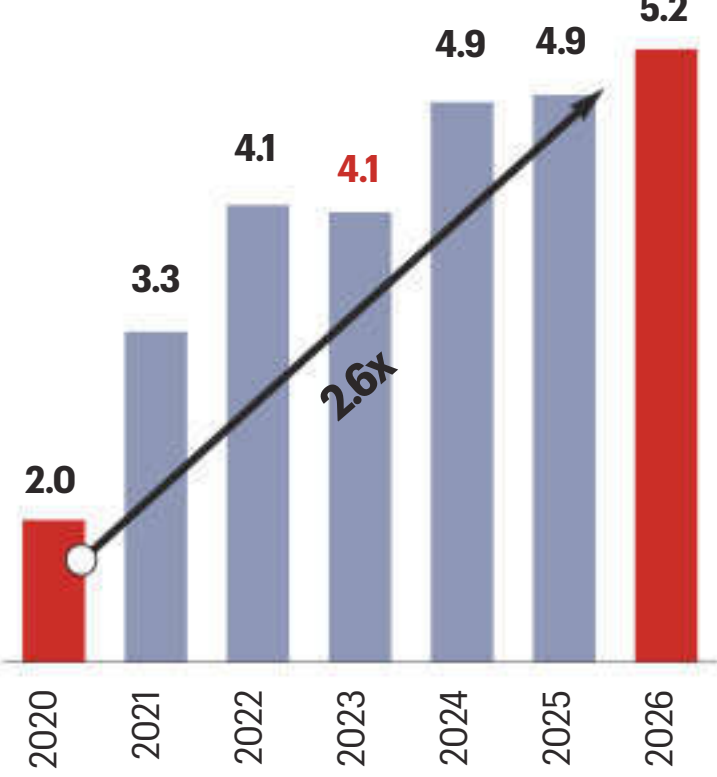
"However, he noted that the agreement signed today will open a major pathway for the economic development of both Assam and Nagaland," the MHA release said.

"By creating a framework for cooperation between the governments, this MoU signed in the presence of HM Sh @AmitShah Ji, provides certainty to investors, facilitates operational continuity, enables regulatory coordination and creates conditions necessary for long-term investment decisions," Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said.

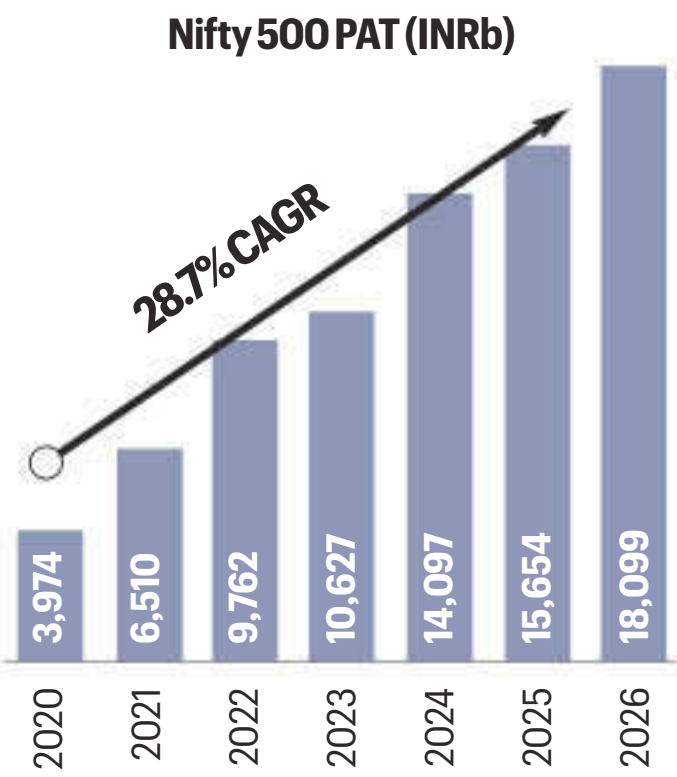
India's corporate profit-to-GDP ratio soars to record 5.2% in FY26

The corporate profit-to-GDP ratio soared to an all-time high of 5.2% for the Nifty-500 firms in the financial year 2026 (FY26), despite geopolitical headwinds. Corporate profits rose at a faster rate of 15.6% on-year in FY26, outpacing nominal GDP growth of 8.9%.

Corporate profit-to-GDP ratio at an all-time high, up 2.6x in six years



Profits have grown at a faster pace in the last six years



(SOURCE: MOTILAL OSWAL, CAPITALINE, THE RBI, COMPANIES, AND MOFSL DATABASE BASED ON THE CURRENT NIFTY-500 CONSTITUENTS)

Tata's iPhone unit 'contaminated' groundwater: TN pollution body

Reuters
Bengaluru, June 13

AN INDIAN pollution regulator has alleged wastewater discharged from a Tata components factory for Apple's iPhone has contaminated the groundwater for nearby farms and warned of a forced shutdown unless Tata gives a satisfactory explanation.

Tata Electronics is central to Apple's push to diversify iPhone production beyond China and is the second-biggest supplier to Apple in South Asia after Taiwan's Foxconn.

The Tata plant under investigation is in Hosur in southern Tamil Nadu state and makes back panels and other components for iPhones. Farmland owners near the plant had complained for months to the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board

that wastewater from the factory was contaminating their land and open wells.

The complaints led to five state inspections between December 2025 and May 2026, according to details from a previously unreported regulatory notice dated May 25 and reviewed by Reuters.

The inspections found that Tata discharged wastewater into a rainwater harvesting pond inside its facility and that the pond overflowed to contaminate "groundwater in the open wells located in the adjacent agricultural lands", the pollution board's warning notice to Tata said.

Tata had not taken any corrective actions on instructions issued by the pollution board in a previous letter dated December 23, 2025, it said in the three-page notice.

Tata Electronics told Reuters in a statement it had commissioned an independent analysis through an accredited laboratory and that the study determined the company was "in full compliance with all regulatory norms".

Tata said it was "committed to responsible business practices and protection of the environment and local communities", and that it had responded to pollution authorities, although giving no further details.

The pollution board in its May notice asked Tata to explain why power to the unit should not be cut and the unit closed for its alleged breach of the rules. Apple, which has strict rules on how its suppliers handle wastewater, and the Tamil Nadu government did not respond to requests for comment.

IN MARCH, THE PENTAGON HAD DEEMED ANTHROPIC A SUPPLY CHAIN RISK, POTENTIALLY LIMITING ITS USE BY FEDERAL AGENCIES

Why US has barred foreigners from accessing Anthropic's latest AI models

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, June 13

ANTHROPIC HAS suspended all foreign access to its most advanced artificial intelligence (AI) models — Fable 5 and Mythos 5 — after the US government issued an export control order citing national security concerns.

Export controls are typically used to restrict the supply of physical goods to other countries, such as advanced US graphics chips to China.

WHY THE EXPORT CONTROL ORDER?

Anthropic said that it received the US government's order early on June 13, but the communication did not provide specific details of the administration's national security concerns. According to the company, the government possibly believes that it has be-

come aware of a method of bypassing, or "jailbreaking" Fable 5. In a blog post, the company said that the order would block all access to Fable 5 and Mythos 5 by any foreign national, whether inside or outside the United States, including foreign national Anthropic employees. "We reviewed a demonstration of this specific technique being used to identify a small number of previously known, minor vulnerabilities. These vulnerabilities all appear relatively simple, and we have found that other publicly-available models are able to discover them as well without requiring a bypass," Anthropic said.

But, it cautioned that the US government had only given Anthropic "verbal evidence" of a "potential narrow, non-universal jailbreak, which essentially consists of asking the



Anthropic said the US government's order did not provide specific details of the administration's national security concerns. REUTERS

model to read a specific code-base and fix any software flaws". "Our understanding is that one potential jailbreak was shared with the government. We have reviewed a report that we believe is the basis of the government's directive and validated that the level of capability displayed there is widely

available from other models (including OpenAI's GPT-5.5), and is used every day by the defenders who keep systems safe," the company said in its blogpost.

In March, after talks over how Anthropic's AI could be used in military operations, the Pentagon had deemed An-

thropic a supply chain risk, potentially limiting its use by federal agencies. This came after disagreements over how the military could use Claude, with Anthropic insisting on safeguards preventing the AI from being used for mass domestic surveillance or for developing fully autonomous weapons systems.

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thropic a supply chain risk, potentially limiting its use by federal agencies. This came after disagreements over how the military could use Claude, with Anthropic insisting on safeguards preventing the AI from being used for mass domestic surveillance or for developing fully autonomous weapons systems.

tems. The order comes as Anthropic is preparing for public listing in the US, after being recently valued \$965 billion.

WHAT ARE ANTHROPIC'S FABLE 5 AND MYTHOS 5?

Fable 5 and Mythos 5, launched earlier this week, are Anthropic's most advanced publicly available AI models. They are built on the underlying "Mythos-class" architecture — the company's other AI model named Mythos Preview which it has not released publicly over fears of misuse.

Anthropic had previously claimed that Mythos Preview was able to find severe vulnerabilities in "every major operating system and web browser", including one that had gone undetected for nearly three decades — spooking regulators around the world for its potential impact on critical infrastructure.

The company had started giving exclusive access to a select few organisations under its Project Glasswing. In India, Anthropic was discussing sharing Mythos Preview with a handful of entities, but was yet to share the model.

Since the company was not able to publicly release Mythos Preview, it announced earlier this week that it would launch Fable 5 and Mythos 5 instead, which are both based on the same underlying model, but have additional safeguards baked in. In particular, requests related to sensitive cybersecurity or biological domains are filtered. When the system detects a potentially high-risk query, it automatically routes the user to a less capable model rather than allowing the request to be handled by the full Mythos-level system.

"We've therefore launched

the model with safeguards that mean queries on some topics will instead receive a response from our next-most-capable model, Claude Opus 4.8.

To release the model both safely and quickly, we've tuned these safeguards conservatively—they'll sometimes catch harmless requests, though they trigger, on average, in less than 5% of sessions. With more capable models arriving in the coming months, we're working to improve our safeguards and reduce false positives as quickly as we can," Anthropic said in a blog post earlier.

The company also said that for a small group of cyber experts and infrastructure providers, it was launching Claude Mythos 5. It's the same underlying model as Fable 5, but with the safeguards lifted in some areas.